

Geography and Economic Development (revisited)

Summary in brief

Dupas, P. (2026). Geography and economic development (revisited). In P. Dupas, P. Goldberg, & R. Pande (Eds.), *Handbook of development economics* (Vol. 6A). Elsevier. Draft dated March 4, 2026. Princeton University.

What the chapter does

A review of the evidence on geography's *causal* impact on economic development — not the correlations, but what can actually be identified.

The methodological shift it documents

- The literature has moved beyond cross-country correlations, the staple of the earlier geography-and-growth debate.
- It now exploits natural experiments, historical shocks, and fine-grained spatial variation to isolate causal effects.

The three geographic domains reviewed

- **Disease burden** — the causal role of the local epidemiological environment.
- **Climate and soil conditions** — agricultural potential and climatic constraints.
- **Topographical constraints** — terrain, ruggedness, and access.

Central findings

- Geographical factors have clear causal effects on development outcomes.
- Those effects operate both directly and indirectly.
- Sub-Saharan Africa is at a particular geographic disadvantage.
- Climate change will only exacerbate that disadvantage.

Summary drawn from the chapter's abstract. An expanded version — section by section, with the specific studies cited — can be produced from the full draft.